



MEMORIES WOVEN
Designers are turning Kerala’s familiar sights and feelings into new-season statements **P9**

metro PLUS THE **HINDU**

Where Chennai falls in love

As Chennai turns 387, we bring you a list of four lovers’ haunts through distinct romantic memories

Chennai is full of quiet corners made for two. Between the city’s creeks, chugging trains, cadets, and coastlines, Team Weekend tells you about four date spots for four different moods. Through them, we promise you a memory each. Loving though, solely involves your labour.

FULL STORY ON
» PAGE 4

PHOTO: KADHAIGAL BY NANDHANANDH MARAN

Organised by



Dr. KAMAKSHI
MEMORIAL HOSPITALS

Supported by



Every Step supports limb preservation

A Public Awareness Initiative by Dr.Kamakshi Memorial Hospitals on Peripheral Artery Disease and prevention of amputation towards an amputation free Tamil Nadu.

For many, vascular disease can put that everyday freedom at risk. Early awareness, timely diagnosis and appropriate treatment can make a vital difference in preserving a limb.



Dr. Venkateshwar,
Senior Vascular Surgeon,
Dr.Kamakshi Memorial Hospitals
explains the importance of Peripheral Artery Disease

Recognising the warning signs of Peripheral Artery Disease (PAD) and seeking timely care can help protect the limb. Through the Amputation-Free Tamil Nadu Marathon, Dr. Kamakshi Memorial Hospitals aims to spread awareness about vascular health and limb preservation

WHY THIS RUN MATTERS

- PAD affects millions but often goes undetected.
- Early awareness can prevent amputation.
- Timely care restores mobility and saves lives.
- Your run today can change someone's future.



WHAT EXACTLY IS PERIPHERAL ARTERY DISEASE?

Peripheral Artery Disease, or PAD, occurs when the arteries supplying blood to the legs become narrowed or blocked, commonly due to the build-up of fatty deposits and calcium. This reduces blood flow to the legs and feet.



HOW COMMON IS PERIPHERAL ARTERY DISEASE, AND WHY SHOULD WE BE CONCERNED?

PAD is more common than many people realise, particularly among people with diabetes, those who smoke or use tobacco, and those with high blood pressure or high cholesterol. Because the condition can progress gradually and may sometimes cause little or no pain, it can go unnoticed until it becomes serious. If blood flow is severely reduced, wounds may not heal properly, and the limb can ultimately be at risk.



WHY IS EARLY TREATMENT SO IMPORTANT?

When blood supply to the foot is poor, even a small wound can become difficult to heal. This risk can be greater in people with diabetes. Infection and tissue damage can ultimately threaten the limb.
The earlier a vascular problem is identified and treated, the greater the opportunity to protect the limb and preserve mobility.



AS A VASCULAR SURGEON, WHAT WOULD YOU LIKE PEOPLE TO TAKE AWAY FROM THIS MESSAGE?

The ability to walk, move and live independently is something we often take for granted. But vascular disease can threaten that freedom, especially when warning signs are overlooked or treatment is delayed. My message is simple: know your risk, don't ignore a non-healing wound or changes in your feet, and seek medical advice early.



SCAN TO REGISTER

REGISTER NOW
RUN KIT • FINISHER MEDAL • CERTIFICATE
REFRESHMENTS • BREAKFAST

📞 74483 76434 | 75500 76477

<https://reg.myraceindia.com/form/run26>

**RUN TODAY.
SAVE A LIMB
TOMORROW**

Worried about PAD or the risk of amputation due to diabetes, smoking, high BP or high cholesterol?
Speak to Dr. Venkateshwar for a FREE discussion.

📞 +91 44 66 300 300

SUNDAY - 23 AUGUST 2026
6K ₹ 399 | 12K ₹ 499

START & FINISH
VELS UNIVERSITY PALLAVARAM
Route through Pallikaranai

pick of the week



Ladakh on a plate

Embark on a culinary journey to Ladakh this weekend as award-winning Chef Nilza Wangmo of Alchi Kitchen brings the flavours of her mountain home to Zhouyu, in collaboration with *The Hindu* Lit for Life Unplugged. Expect Ladakhi favourites such as mok mok, chhutagi, chulli salad, apricot and apple crumble, gugur cha and khambir. Lunch and dinner on August 15. For reservations, log on to zhouyu.in/events.



Forgotten heroes

This Independence Day, Heritage Stories and Performing Arts (HSPA) will present Ithihaas Ke Pannon Se, a programme celebrating the unsung efforts of freedom fighters from Tamil Nadu. One of the highlights is a villupattu performance by Kalaimamani awardee Bharathi Thirumurugan and team. August 16, 6pm onwards *Kalakshetra Foundation Auditorium, Thiruvannamipur*. Tickets at ₹200 onwards. For further details call, 9167400670.



Know your city?

Put your city smarts to the test at the Madras Quiz for Schools, hosted by Murugappa Group, where nostalgia meets trivia and old Madras shakes hands with new Chennai. From iconic landmarks and quirky historical nuggets to beloved personalities, expect a day packed with fun, facts, and friendly competition, hosted by veteran quizmaster Sumanth C Raman. On August 23, at *Victoria Public Hall, 10am onwards*. Register on <https://tinyurl.com/pt97zc9d>



Lessons in laughter

Ready for a comedy lesson you will not forget? Maya S Krishnan brings her solo physical comedy special *Pomblel* and her hilarious alter ego, Manjula Teacher, to Chennai. Expect satire, physical comedy, and plenty of laughs as she tackles sexism, misogyny, and the everyday absurdities of being a woman. *Catch it live at the Music Academy, TTK Road, on August 15 at 7pm; tickets are on Ticket9 and the show is for ages 18+.* Tickets start ₹750 onwards.



THE NAKED TRUTH

Cubicles & Cupid

Workplace relationships are alive and well, but in 2026 the bigger conversation is about consent, hierarchy, disclosure and reputation

The office romance is having a strange little moment. We have spent the last decade making workplaces safer, more professional and increasingly conscious of boundaries, and yet we still cannot stop fancying the person sitting across the meeting room. A 2025 YouGov survey for dating app Ashley Madison found that 40% of Indian respondents had dated or were currently dating a colleague, putting India second among the 11 countries surveyed. The caveat, obviously, is that Ashley Madison is a platform built around disreput relationships, so this isn't exactly a census of Corporate India. Still, 40% is difficult to dismiss as an HR aberration. "Workplaces have always been a breeding ground for romance, and I don't think that's about to change anytime soon," says Radhika Agrawal, author of *Not Safe For Work* (HarperCollins). "Where else do you even meet

people offline these days? We spend 8-9 hours a day at the office with the same group of people, so it's only natural that we get to know our colleagues inside out and often develop feelings for them." But what has changed isn't necessarily our appetite for office romance. It is our tolerance for the mess that follows.

A former HR executive with the Tata Group tells me that employees would sometimes come to HR because relationships between colleagues had become "very disruptive", particularly when couples were on the same team. A fight could turn into what she describes as a "cold war": two people who had once worked perfectly well together

suddenly stopped speaking, avoided each other and forced the rest of the team to navigate the fallout. Tata's equal-opportunity statement says it respects employees' right to privacy and does not concern itself with conduct outside work unless it affects performance, creates a conflict of interest or adversely affects the company.

After hours An IT professional from Hyderabad has arrived at a similar conclusion, albeit before anything had the opportunity to go wrong. He says he knows plenty of colleagues who go out for dinner and coffee but deliberately keep things platonic because there is, in his words, "a sense of ownership and responsibility" about not making the workplace murky. He had liked a colleague himself. They worked in different departments, so there was no direct reporting relationship. But then they noticed something: every date somehow became another meeting. "We started discussing work

everywhere we went," he says. "We realised that it would never be something where we could share our interests." So they took "a hard stand": they still meet, but keep it platonic. And women may have more reason to worry about what happens once a romance becomes office property. A study of close to 1,000 adults across US industries by Rebecca Chory, Lisa Mainiero and Sean Horan, published in the *International Journal of Business Communication*, found that workplace romances were perceived as more damaging to women's careers than men's. One woman I spoke to knows exactly what that can feel like. Her romance with a colleague began with "cute banter", shared notes after meetings and long evenings working together on presentations. They went for coffee and dinner. Then colleagues started talking. Eventually, she realised he was telling people about their relationship more openly than she was. "It became really awkward," she tells me. What had felt mutual and private suddenly had an audience. Eventually, she asked to be transferred. And then there is the line companies really cannot afford to ignore: hierarchy. This changing power dynamic is exactly what Radhika wanted to explore in *Not Safe For Work*. "Traditionally speaking, when we've seen workplace romances represented in pop culture or even discussed IRL, there's been a stereotypical dynamic of a powerful male boss and a younger female subordinate," she says. "But workplaces are changing, with more women taking on senior leadership roles." So in her novel, Kavya is the boss, and Neil is the intern. In 2026, one should know what happens when attraction meets hierarchy, gossip, power and the Monday morning meeting.

A fortnightly guide to love in the age of bare minimum

Vivek Man Sherchan, owner of the Jimbu Thakali restaurant chain; (right) the Cheli Jwai Thali. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Beyond momos

Jimbu Thakali's first Indian restaurant brings the food of Nepal's Mustang region to Gurgaon

Ayaan Paul Chowdhury
ayaan.paul@thehindu.co.in

Delhi has become synonymous with a seemingly endless parade of increasingly questionable variations on the momo, as though Nepal's vast culinary heritage begins and ends with a dumpling stuffed with whatever new abomination Delhiites currently find exciting. Very few restaurants in the city have attempted to engage with the breadth of Nepali food beyond momos, and fewer still have managed to present it with an authenticity. To address that gap, one of the country's popular restaurant chains has finally opened its doors in Delhi-NCR: Jimbu Thakali, a Kathmandu-born chain devoted to the cuisine of Nepal's Thakali community. Now open at M3M 65th Avenue in Gurgaon, Jimbu is heavily rooted in Nepal. Vivek Man Sherchan is the

hospitality entrepreneur behind Jimbu, which began in Kathmandu in 2016 and now has four outlets across Nepal. When the devastating 2015 earthquake forced him to reconsider the business, the restaurant that emerged from that disruption eventually became Jimbu Thakali. "I decided, when in Rome, you know?" Vivek tells me. "What's the most popular palate in Nepal?" His answer was the food people were already eating at home, particularly rice-based meals served with vegetables, dal and an assortment of accompaniments. "The Thakali thali is basically a staple," he says. "The thali itself, is something that the average



Nepali household consumes almost every day." Jimbu's version developed around the idea that families could eat the food they knew while enjoying the convenience of eating out. Thakali cuisine itself comes from the Thak Khola region of Mustang, where the Thakali community historically lived along the Kali Gandaki trade corridor. Mustang's altitude shaped what could be cultivated, while its position along trade routes brought outside ingredients and culinary influences into the region. Buckwheat became particularly important, while jimbu, timur and fermented foods acquired distinctive roles in the cuisine. The Mustang-spiced potatoes are among the simplest things I ate, and perhaps the easiest to underestimate. The mushroom choila was another favourite, served cold and coated in Newari spices that give the mushrooms a sharp, acidic edge against their chilled texture.

The mutton momos are more immediately familiar, although their appeal comes from the effort behind the filling and seasoning rather than novelty. But the highlight for me was the cheli jwai Thali, named after the Nepali term for a son-in-law. The idea, as Vivek explains, is that "when the son-in-law comes home, you pamper him with an extravagant meal". Sherchan attributes much of Jimbu's culinary identity to his mother, whose recipes form the foundation of the Thakali menu. "Our entire Thakali menu is based on my mom's recipes," he says. With a history this curious baked into its walls, Jimbu Thakali definitely feels like a new culinary homestyle experience worth seeking out, especially if you're ready to move beyond Delhi's momo obsession and taste the Nepal that exists beyond the dumpling.

A meal for two costs approximately ₹2,000.

Silk road South

The iconic Thai silk brand, founded by Jim Thompson, enters South India with luxury home furnishings

Privamedha Dutta
priyamedha.dutta@thehindu.co.in

In 1967, an American businessman went for an afternoon walk in the Cameron Highlands of Malaysia and was never seen again. No clear explanation ever surfaced – only theories, ranging from tiger attacks to Cold War intrigue. That man was Jim Thompson, who transformed the fortunes of Thai silk and brought an age-old craft back into the global spotlight. Delhi-based textile design company RR Décor recently launched Thai luxury and lifestyle brand Jim Thompson at Decorous Lifestyle in Chennai, marking the label's entry into the South Indian market. The collection includes furniture fabrics, cushions, throws, curtains and blinds, bedding, and tapestries. Jim moved to Thailand in 1945 while serving with the US Office of Strategic Services (OSS), the US intelligence agency, which later became the CIA. Stationed in Bangkok at the end of the Second World War, he was captivated by the country's architecture and traditional crafts. Declining to return to the US after the war, Thompson decided to turn his attention to the dying Thai silk industry. "He was so fascinated by the colour, the texture, the individuality, and the human touch of the artisans. Because it was all handloom and handwoven,

he really put a lot of effort into it. He introduced many new techniques in weaving, styling, and design, and by the early '60s, Thai silk had become a globally accepted fabric," says Rohit Khemka, founder, RR Décor. Ochre and gold dominate much of the collection. Among the standout pieces is Golden Fans, a silk-blend fabric featuring folding-fan motifs woven into a satin base with gilded threads. Inspired by the ceremonial fans of Thailand's royal courts, it combines traditional symbolism with a contemporary aesthetic. Another one is Lost Kingdom, which reimagines Ayutthaya the ancient Thai kingdom; here, gilded details and architectural silhouettes of Siamese temples are showcased in a way that tells the story of a generation. "People often assume Chennai is a market that prefers only subtle designs, but that's changing. People have travelled, they've seen the world, and they're more open to colour and statement pieces now. We wanted to bring that perspective here," says Rohini Vasudevan, chief designer, Decorous Lifestyle. With the latest launch in Chennai, the brand continues to draw from Thailand's artistic and textile traditions, while giving it a contemporary touch.

Decorous Lifestyle is at Gandhi Mandapam Road, Kotturpuram. The collection is priced upwards of ₹30,000.



The Jim Thompson collection at Decorous Lifestyle. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



SMART BAZAAR

FULL PAISA VASOOL SALE

12th -16th Aug

LAST 2 DAYS



FORGET THE OLD MART, AT SMART BAZAAR GET FULL PAISA VASOOL

12th TO 16th AUGUST



SMART PRICE
₹1274

MRP ₹1690
SAVE ₹326

Gold Winner Refined Sunflower Oil 1 L / Good Life Sugar 5 kg

MRP ₹202 / ₹390
SAVE ₹26 / ₹41



SMART PRICE
₹176 / ₹259

MRP ₹189 / ₹198
SAVE ₹50 / ₹29



SMART PRICE
₹469 / ₹479

MRP ₹800 / ₹825
SAVE ₹331 / ₹346



Buy Atta 5 kg & Get ₹25 OFF on any Pack of Edible Oil

MRP ₹315 Onwards



SMART PRICE
₹675

MRP ₹930
SAVE ₹255

Packed Pulses (Entire Range)

MINIMUM 33% OFF

MRP ₹39 Onwards

Biscuits / Chocolate 98 g Onwards (Select Variants)

BUY ANY 2 GET ANY 1 FREE

MRP ₹70 Onwards /Unit

3 Roses Dust Tea 500 g

SAVE ₹80

MRP ₹430 Onwards
SMART Price ₹350 Onwards

Cold Drinks & Juices 1.2 L Onwards (Select Variants)

BUY ANY 2 GET ANY 1 FREE

MRP ₹70 Onwards /Unit

Whole & Blended Spices (Select Range)

MINIMUM 33% OFF

*On MRP

Toothpaste / Soap 125 g Onwards (Multi Pack) (Select Variants)

BUY ANY 1 GET ANY 1 FREE

MRP ₹270 Onwards

Shampoo 580 ml Onwards (Select Variants)

FLAT 60% OFF

MRP ₹840 Onwards
SMART Price ₹336 Onwards

Detergents 5 kg / 3.6 L Onwards (Select Variants)

MINIMUM 33% OFF

MRP ₹565 Onwards

2 Pcs Stainless Steel Triply Cookware Combo (Kadhai 22 cm / Fry Pan 24 cm)

SMART PRICE
₹999

MRP ₹3649

Double Bedsheet Set with Pillow Cover (Select Variants)

FLAT 75% OFF

MRP ₹1799 Onwards
SMART Price ₹450 Onwards

LARAH 28 Pcs Opalware Dinner Set

SMART PRICE
₹1499

MRP ₹6649



SMART STYLE SAVINGS

2000+ Fashion Styles

UPTO 50% OFF

*Select Merchandise

NOW OPEN CHENNAI - 83/1 Thiruneermalai Road, Nagalkeni Chrompet.

CHENNAI - Ambattur - Kallikuppam, BARGUR - Krishnagiri Main Road, CUDDALORE - Near KV Textiles, HOSUR - HV Arcade, IYYAPANTHANGAL - Mount Poonamalle High Road, KOLATHUR - Near SS Kalyana Mandapam, MADHAVARAM - Behind Madhavaram Circle Bus Stop, MANAPAKKAM - Near by L&T Back Gate, MARAIMALAI NAGAR - Maraimalai Nagar Industrial Complex, MOGAPPAIR - Bharathi Salai, Phase -2, Nolambur, NAVALUR - Vivira Mall, PALAVAKKAM - East Coast Road, PERAMBUR - M.P.M Road, ROYAPETTAH - Express Avenue Mall, REDHILLS - Lakshmi Theater Bypass Service Road, Padiyanallur Near R.B Grand Marriage Hall, SRIPERUMBUDUR - Tambaram Mudichur Road, Bangalore Highway, Near Hotel Rayyan, VADAPALANI - Near AVM Studio, VELACHERY - Phoenix Market City, VELLORE - Near Lakshmi Theatre. GUDUVANCHERY - GST Road, NPR Kalyana Mandapam, Opp. EB Office, PADUR - Rajiv Gandhi Salai, Near Padur Rountana, PONDICHERRY - Providence Mall.

10% INSTANT DISCOUNT



#Min. Trxn.: ₹3,500; Max. Discount: ₹500 per card; Validity: 12 Aug - 16 Aug 2026. T&C Apply.



BAJAJ FINANCE

Get assured ₹1500 GV on shopping of ₹5,000 or more with Bajaj Easy EMI.

Offer Valid from 31st July - 31st August 2026



Scan to locate your nearest store

Terms and Conditions apply. Offers valid till stocks last. All offers are subject to change without notice. The Pictures / Photographs of the products shown are for representation purpose only. Homeware & Apparel offers are valid in select SMART Bazaar only. Bajaj Finance offer is valid in SMART Bazaar only. MRP of all products are inclusive of all taxes. Discount percentage rounded off to the nearest percentage of the offer price. All offers are valid till 16th August 2026. All disputes are subject to the exclusive jurisdiction of the courts in Mumbai only.



SMART BAZAAR



PHOTO: B VELANKANNI RAJ



Rocky mountain high

Last night I dreamt I went to St Thomas Mount again. (To paraphrase the famed beginning of the Daphne Du Maurier classic, *Rebecca*.) I stood at the bottom of the hill, where once a red mud road wound its way to the shrine that marks the site of the martyrdom of St Thomas, the apostle of Christ. The adjoining Portuguese-built Church of Our Lady of Expectation was built in 1523. The road was macadamised sometime in 1986 to receive Pope John Paul II on his visit.

My love for this grand old neighbourhood came from a childhood summer spent with my grandparents. I often crossed a wooden bridge across a rivulet of the Adyar river to walk to Mount Hotel for a tumbler of Horlicks, another life-long love.

Sunday masses in the 1980s at St Patrick's Church located at the end of Butt Road, before it was renovated, meant watching goats graze among the thorny bushes, nimbly climbing the rocks while the choir sang hymns gloriously. And Christmas was grand, the aroma of cutlets and cake hung heavy in the air, music and lights, and the shouts of 'C'mon girl' as families of Anglo-Indians headed home to Magazine Road and European Lines.

For nearly two decades, through school and college, this old neighbourhood remained a memory, serving sometimes as a shortcut to the Grand Southern Trunk (GST) Road or the occasional Lenten Stations of the Cross on the steps – to the shrine – built by the Armenian merchant Coja Petrus Uscan in 1726.

Until the day I discovered the Officers Training Academy and its old colonial glory on the other side of the hill. The neighbourhood revealed itself like the unfolding of a rose bud. There was the St Thomas Garrison Church at 1 GST Road built for the spiritual needs of the British soldiers of the Madras Artillery headquartered here in 1774. There was the former Military Hospital with its quaint wards, the unit gurudwara across, and further down the road under a spreading banyan tree, the 200-year-old Adyar Mess. There was the Ram Singh Dwar which opened to the Officers Training Academy.

And there was also the young,

dashing Gentleman Cadet who went from friend to beau, even as he was promoted from cadet to captain.

All of a sudden love's look-alike waved to me from every turn at St Thomas Mount. On the rare occasions the captain was on leave, we walked the length of Rudra Road skirting the Mohite Stadium, among the sites of the French siege of Madras in 1759, where later polo matches were held before it became a golfing green.

We stopped to watch the hockey matches outside the gates of St Dominic's school, under an arbour of jasmine flowers and where the raintrees creaked with the weight of history. We laughed at boys diving for coins in the Battery river. We counted the Burmese teak rafters in the old colonial building in one corner and strolled around Lt Col Sam Dalrymple's monument at the other, past old houses with slatted windows, rounded pillars, eaves dovetailed over the roof, and large forecourts with fruit trees.

For years St Thomas Mount was a memory. Until the day I discovered the Officers Training Academy and its old colonial glory on the other side of the hill

We sipped on cold coffee at the cafeteria while OTA cadets cycling past shouted out "Good evening sir, good evening mam."

We walked up the Mount numerous times, by the winding road and the flight of 134 steps, pausing to catch our breath both at the views and the stunning statues that marked Christ's passage on Calvary. Under a large tree was the bust of William Lambton, the geographer-soldier who launched the Great Trigonometrical Survey of India from the Mount.

One evening, rose-ringed clouds scudded across the horizon in a cinematic setting that filmmakers chase whole lifetimes. Crowds of people swirled and eddied around us. On the right was the city, in the far distance the shimmering estuary emptying out into the Bay of Bengal. On the left, airplanes took off and landed on the airport runway next door, the engines roaring as they barely skimmed the tree tops on the Mount. And then above the scream of the jets, the captain leaned in and whispered, "Will you...?"

– Deepa Alexander

A quiet escape

I have found a new favourite place in Chennai. It does not have Instagrammable boards. Nor does it have a cafe.

It's a place that does not announce itself. And yet, it's a place where you can probably find true love. Or a bit of yourself.

This spot is in Adyar, a neighbourhood that sits in the intersection of everything Chennai: a neighbourhood filled with commercial buildings co-existing with a heady dose of green spaces.

If the term 'tucked away' had a visual, it would be this. This walk-through park is located at a dead end and is hardly visible to the outside world, making it one of Chennai's perfect date spots.

And why this park and not any others here? Because, most others have become 'family friendly'. Somewhere, the kids are pestering their parents for one last ride on the slide. Or, the elderly are trying to get their arms and shoulders in shape by driving some sort of a fitness wheel which exists for reasons that are beyond comprehension. Or worse, the biggest park scam, the 'pebble walk' – where you walk barefoot for the wellness of your feet. Maybe this was designed to benefit slipper thieves in the neighbourhood.

Sorry, I'm joking. More importantly, I'm digressing.

Back to the star location of this tale: the walkway, where busy city life comes to a standstill. Take a walk among these wooded paths for hours of conversation with your partner; it's inexpensive, can burn off a few calories and gives you the

space and time for a memorable tete-a-tete. You could start walking in Adyar and exit in Kotturpuram.

Early evenings are ideal here. Especially if the weather is your friend because when it rains, this walk-way is shut. Watch out for a couple of not-so-friendly dogs, a tottering guard who insists on locking up on the dot at 6pm. At times, even cops land up here to check if all is in order. All these technicalities remind me a bit of another Chennai dating rite of passage: the Broken Bridge, where romance and Municipal disapproval co-exist.

Here, you can overlook a calm, still river and be lost in your thoughts for hours. Here, you can watch a couple of squirrels frolic up and down the trees. In between taking in all these, you can have life-changing conversations.

Either with your partner, or with yourself, or with the trees.

It is also one of those rare initiatives of the Greater Chennai Corporation that has got many things right: trees along the Adyar river, while creating a green space for residents to walk. There are more plans for this place, if the recent Tamil Nadu Budget 2026 is anything to go by. A few years down the line, you could probably take a boat ride and stroll in a recreational riverfront.

And if that happens... I would be the first in queue to purchase a ticket and check out my favourite walking place from the waters. The tottering watchman would probably still be on guard, looking at me and wondering: *Ada-yaaru?* (Look who's here!)

– Srinivasa Ramanujam

PHOTO: SHIVARAJ S



Love comes in waves

Disclaimer: No sundal, garbage bins, or dupattas, have been harmed during the making of these love stories. The same however, cannot be said about love itself.

The year was 2012. Everyone was convinced that the world would be pulverised on December 12 because the Mayan calendar said so. I was far more concerned about the fact that TRAI allowed me only a maximum of 100 free messages a day as part of the SMS pack. I had to find ways to confess my feelings to the love of my life without wasting all the messages on fluff texts mostly because we were going to die.

"Beach?" I texted him at 3.30pm.

"I think I like you. I'm not sure if I can be in a relationship because we're both in Class XII and we must focus. But if you'd like, we can quasi-date and meet at the beach when we're both free. After the boards though, we can be girlfriend-boyfriend," I said, in garbled word-salad tongue.

At the Besant Nagar beach's walk-way, as we stood avoiding eye contact, my crush turned to me and said "*Enakku* okay" and began walking to the shore. I was secretly overjoyed but tried impossibly hard to stop myself from beaming throughout. Our hands brushed a little as the waves lapped at our feet, but we ended up talking about all the happenings at Maths tuition and forgot that we were now secretly in love.

Three weeks later, when I stepped out of school, I saw him 'doublesing' my best friend on his cycle. She held

his uniform shirt as holding his hips would be too forward. That evening, I cycled to the beach, cried and listened to Adele crooning '*Never mind I'll find someone like you*'. The world did not end that year but my chaste, innocent, puppy-like affection sure did. After this, I was going to be fearless in love and otherwise, I declared.

It is why years of navigating Chennai's impossible dating scene has taken me to many beaches, part of the city's bejewelled coastline to pursue my romances. Entry has always been free, and if you are lucky, a man selling soan papdi on a push-cart along the shore, might serve you a cone of the puffy-white cloud-like sweet.

I've made a sacred promise to the sea gods to gate-keep my favourite beach for fear of crowds, but today, some of the beaches I enjoy visiting, especially along the city's coastline for

dates include the Pazhaverkadu Beach, the unmarked rock-filled stretches along Kasimedu, and the unnamed beach by the Harbour. Certain stretches along the Marina, particularly the one opposite the PWD office, where fishing boats are docked early in the morning, and the portions off Loop Road in the evenings (avoid early mornings if you fear exposed derrieres) offer stunning views to lover's quarrels, if any.

Lately, I have been frequenting the portions near Thiruvannmiyur beach, particularly late at night, when people dissolve into shadows. This is unless the moon decides to unleash its ferocious, soft light on lovers. The setting is perfect if you want to lie down, watch the stars, and sink your teeth in all that Eros has to offer, but best not to stroll past 10pm. The police will turn up and it is not worth the hassle. If you are a prude and do not approve of public

displays of affection, avoid the beaches in the afternoon at all cost. For years, the coastline has hosted lovers' conventions where dupattas and dustbins have been used with utmost creativity. People have often written poetry both on the sand and on each other's bodies.

The sandy coastline also makes for a dramatic background for a breakup. If that is where your relationship is headed, sit by the shore in silence and let your jilted lover sob after saying "It's over". Leave, contemplating all that life has given you and all that you have lost. The water possesses the ability to heal.

Trust me. I'd know. If the waves don't help though, there is always, always a packet of sundal and a shawarma shop round the corner.

– Sanjana Ganesh

PHOTO: FREEZELOURS PHOTOGRAPHY



Platforms, and parting ways

Every time I listen to 'Malai Kovil Vaasalil,' I mourn who I was when I sat next to her on that MRTS train. Ilaiyaraaja was speaking for us through an audio jack splitter that rested gently on our interlocked arms. I still remember how the orange streetlights outside lit her face, her eyes conveying the unease she felt after we ended a difficult conversation.

I can still remember the measured diction with which she told me it was okay and that we would get through it together. Ragini* (name changed) waved goodbye as I boarded my train back – I am still not sure who was leaving whom. For thousands of hopeless romantics, the railway station is a lovers' haunt that becomes something more, an otherworld where everyone is in a hurry but you, and yours.

It has seen just as many tearful heartbreaks as the Marina. But at the Egmore railway station, on Independence Day 2023, I saw that some goodbyes can show you all the love you have left to share with the world. Just a couple of days ago, I had matched with Hasini* on a dating app. But the story seemed like it would end even before it could start – she was in Chennai on vacation and was soon going back to Tiruchi. She told me she was on her way to Egmore. "Low-key thinking of chasing that train *DDLJ* style. But okay," I sent. "Come," she replied, and my pulse raced instantly.

It was 10pm, and Rockfort Express was scheduled to depart at 11.30. I took off to Egmore like The Flash. I had to get her something, but who would sell flowers at that hour. But as it happened, a handful of *thaenmittai* wrapped in a newspaper was what was in store. Who wouldn't like *thaenmittai*?

She stretched her hand and waved goodbye. This was our Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge moment

I can't recollect much of what we talked about on the bench; I was too taken aback by the absurdity of the moment, knowing she would eventually have to run back in to not be caught seen with a strange man at this hour by her college roommate's parents. She texted an apology from inside the train and promised to come out to say bye from the door when the train departed. Rockfort Express began pulling away, but there was no sign of her. I walked alongside the compartment in anguish until the train suddenly stopped. Hasini appeared at the door with a grin so wide it still fills me with joy – the same joy that made me run after her when the train started again, paying no heed to onlookers. She stretched her hand and waved goodbye. This was our *Dilwale Dulhania Le Jayenge*, even if it only lasted for an evening. The date went well, but I never saw Hasini again (and as it turns out, she didn't like *thaenmittai*).

And as is with life, I wasn't nearly done with railway stations. Neither was love done with me. Later that same year, the Guindy MRTS railway station grew from a dating spot to a world unto itself. In a relationship filled with uncertainty, Meena* and I decided to have our own 'Montauk' in Chennai, inspired by *The Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind*. "Meet me in Montauk" became a lighthouse phrase, and a bench at the railway station where we spent many rainy evenings under a shared umbrella became a safehouse destination we vowed to find each other, or ourselves, at 8pm on Thursdays, should we get separated by the powers that be. Later, you could have found me sitting alone at Guindy, every Thursday at 8, for more than a month before I realised Meena was gone for good. And yet, that stone bench could tell you all about the poetry we wrote with rainwater under an umbrella.

Even today, for thousands of hopeless Madrasvaasis, railway stations continue to create memories we wouldn't forget in a lifetime. They live in Ilaiyaraaja's music, the blare of the train horns, the clatter of the tracks, dusty local-train windows, stone benches with a beating heart, and in the promises of a better future.

– Bhuvanesh Chandar

Pulse of Nation

From Freedom to Wellbeing: India at 80

Organised by

**Dr. KAMAKSHI
MEMORIAL HOSPITALS**

Every Step supports limb preservation

 www.drkmh.com

Supported by



MARATHON RUN FOR AN
AMPUTATION FREE TAMIL NADU

SUNDAY - 23 AUGUST 2026

6K ₹ 399 | 12K ₹ 499

START & FINISH

VELS UNIVERSITY PALLAVARAM
Route through Pallikaranai

74483 76434 | 75500 76477


SCAN TO REGISTER

REGISTER NOW

RUN KIT • FINISHER MEDAL • CERTIFICATE
REFRESHMENTS • BREAKFAST



The Freedom to Be Healthy

Haarshini Agarwal

Independence is usually spoken about in the language of borders, movements, and the making of a nation. But 80 years after India raised the tricolor as a free nation, the idea of freedom has acquired many more meanings. It is the freedom to learn, work, travel, dream, create and build a life on one's own terms.

And somewhere at the foundation of all these freedoms is something remarkably simple: good health.

Healthcare may not be the first thing that comes to mind when we think of Independence Day. Yet, look closer and the connection becomes clear. The freedom to live a full life depends, in no small measure, on the ability to access healthcare when we need it, understand our bodies better and receive the right care at the right time.

Over the past eight decades, India's healthcare landscape has changed dramatically. From the expansion of medical institutions and public health programmes to the growth of specialised hospitals, diagnostics, pharmaceuticals and medical research, the country has built a healthcare ecosystem that is far more expansive than it was at Independence.

Today, a patient can walk into a specialised centre for cardiac care, oncology, orthopaedics, fertility, neurology or minimally invasive surgery. Medical technology has made procedures more precise, diagnostics more sophisticated and treatment options more diverse. India's medical professionals and institutions have also become an important part of the country's global healthcare presence.

But healthcare is not only about what happens inside a hospital.

Perhaps one of the biggest shifts in recent years has been the growing importance of preventive healthcare. There is a difference between waiting for the body to signal a problem and actively taking steps to protect it. Regular health checks, vaccinations, nutritious food, physical activity, adequate sleep, and mental wellbeing are increasingly becoming part of the larger conversation around health.

This is where healthcare intersects beautifully with the idea of independence.

Being informed about one's health is a form of personal agency. Knowing the warning signs of an illness, understanding family health risks, keeping track of routine screenings, or simply knowing when it is time to consult a doctor can help people make better decisions.

The conversation has also moved from treating individuals to thinking about the health of communities. Public health initiatives have shown how healthcare can influence an entire generation. Maternal and child healthcare, immunisation, sanitation, nutrition, and awareness programmes can shape outcomes long before someone enters a hospital.

A nation's health is closely tied to its ability to progress.

Consider the simple example of a classroom. A child who receives adequate nutrition, preventive care and timely treatment



has a better chance of attending school, learning, and participating fully. Similarly, a healthy workforce can contribute more confidently to businesses, industries, and communities. When older adults have access to appropriate healthcare, they can remain active and engaged with their families and communities.

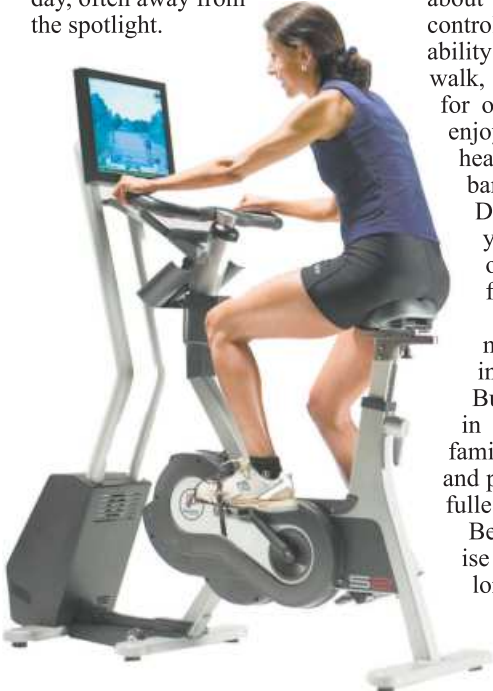
Healthcare, then, is not merely a service. It is part of the infrastructure of opportunity.

India's healthcare story is also increasingly being shaped by technology. Telemedicine has made consultations possible across geographical distances. Digital health records can help connect information across different points of care. Artificial intelligence is finding applications in diagnostics and clinical decision-making. Wearable devices are encouraging people to pay closer attention to everyday indicators such as activity, sleep, and heart rate.

The significance of these developments lies not simply in the technology itself, but in what it can enable: greater access, faster information, and more informed healthcare decisions.

At the same time, the human element remains at the heart of medicine.

Every technological advancement eventually comes back to a person sitting across from a doctor, a nurse reassuring a patient, a technician carefully conducting a test or a caregiver helping someone through recovery. India's healthcare professionals have played a quiet but extraordinary role in the nation's progress. Their work continues every day, often away from the spotlight.



Independence Day offers an opportunity to acknowledge that contribution. The tricolor is a symbol of a nation's collective journey, and healthcare forms an important part of that journey. The doctors working in operating rooms, nurses caring for patients through long shifts, researchers looking for better treatments, pharmacists ensuring medicines reach people, paramedics responding when every minute matters and caregivers supporting families all contribute to the health of the country.

There is another dimension to this story: healthcare gives people the confidence to imagine a longer future.

A young person managing a health condition can continue pursuing a career. A parent receiving timely treatment can return to the family waiting at home. A senior citizen with appropriate preventive care can remain active and independent. These may seem like individual stories, but together they form the larger story of a healthier nation.

As India looks towards the decades ahead, the definition of healthcare will continue to evolve. The hospitals of tomorrow may be more technologically advanced, diagnostics may become increasingly personalised and preventive care may become more deeply integrated into everyday life.

But the larger goal will remain familiar: helping people live healthier, longer and more fulfilling lives.

That is perhaps where Independence Day and healthcare meet most meaningfully. Freedom is not only about being free from external control. It is also about having the ability to participate in life fully. To walk, learn, work, celebrate, care for others, pursue ambitions and enjoy ordinary moments without health becoming an unnecessary barrier. So, this Independence Day, as India celebrates 80 years of freedom, healthcare offers another reason to look forward.

A nation's progress can be measured in buildings, roads, industries, and innovations. But it can also be measured in healthier children, stronger families, better-informed citizens, and people who can live life to its fullest.

Because the ultimate promise of progress is not simply a longer life.

It is the freedom to live that life well.

As India celebrates 80 years of freedom, healthcare emerges as the foundation for a healthier, stronger, and more empowered nation.

When IVF Doesn't Work...

For couples who are unable to conceive naturally, assisted fertility techniques such as IVF are seen as the means to fulfil their dream of becoming parents. When the treatment does not result in a pregnancy, the couple may end up disappointed, frustrated and helpless. More so for couples who go through more than one IVF cycle but are not able to conceive.

If you have experienced this, please don't blame yourself. IVF is a medical procedure, and there are several reasons as to why you may not have conceived successfully – and it is helpful to be aware of key reasons so that you can relieve yourself of the built-up sense of pressure and focus on next steps.

A key factor is the **choice of the doctor and IVF / fertility centre**. Couples should research the facility and check if it is accredited with the right standards. Their technicians should have adequate training, and

the centre should have high air quality, culture quality and durable medical equipment. Also, do look into the doctors' qualifications and experience.

The **woman's age and health** are important factors. As a woman becomes older, she has fewer eggs, and these eggs tend to decline in quality. Due to this, the strength of the resulting embryo is lower. Another important factor is the health of the woman's uterus. A weak uterus or the presence of big and/or multiple fibroids in the uterine wall can reduce the possibility of a successful pregnancy.

The **man's reproductive health**, particularly sperm health, also plays a key role. Thus, it is vital for male partners to screen and analyse their sperm cells for low motility, morphological, genetic or DNA fragmentation defects.

Lifestyle and habits also play an important. Irregular or lack of

**Dr. K.S. Kavitha Gautham,**
MBBS, MS (OG)
Managing Director,
BloomLife Hospital Pvt. Ltd.

physical activity, excessive weight gain or obesity, unhealthy diet and excessive smoking and drinking can negatively impact their chances of successful IVF conception.

If your IVF cycle was not successful...

Get a second opinion on what could be the reason and work with the doctor to address it. A positive mindset and can-do attitude are half the bridge crossed – and we are there to help you through the other half.

For fertility and pregnancy guidance from an individualised, holistic perspective, Call
+91-72999 11107.

**SRM**
DIAGNOSTICS
detect. decode. restore.

**80 YEARS**

80 YEARS OF FREEDOM.
A PROMISE OF GOOD HEALTH.

**PREVENT TODAY,
PROTECT TOMORROW.**

**ACCURATE RESULTS,
BETTER DECISIONS.**

**QUALITY YOU CAN RELY ON,
CARE YOU CAN COUNT ON.**

**80
ESSENTIAL
TESTS**
80% OFFER
~~MRP ₹4000~~
OFFER PRICE
₹800/-
**OFFER VALID
FROM
AUG 15TH - AUG 31ST**

PACKAGE

• CBC – (20 Tests)

• FBS – (1 Test)

• HbA1c – (1 Test)

• Lipid Profile – (9 Tests)

• Liver Function Tests – (11 Tests)

• Kidney Function Tests – (9 Tests)

• TFT – Total – (3 Tests)

• Iron Profile – (4 Tests)

• Urine Routine – (22 Tests)

FOR HOME COLLECTION
 **88 38 300 300**

 www.srmdiagnostics.com
 info@srmdiagnostics.com

Chennai | Coimbatore | Chengalpattu
Dharmapuri | Krishnagiri | Kanchipuram
Kalyakkavilai | Madurai | Pollachi | Ramnad
Tiruvallur | Theni | Trichy | Thirunelveli

CM
YK







A



Nidhi Adlakha
nidhi.adlakha@thehindu.co.in

Going on a safari is like visiting someone's home uninvited. You are not quite sure whether they will be home, and even if they are, you can never really tell whether they will greet you. My first visit to the Nagarhole Tiger Reserve – an approximately five-hour drive from Bengaluru – this monsoon was a similarly bittersweet experience. I was up before sunrise, and a steaming cup of black coffee later, boarded a jeep to the State-run Jungle Lodges and Resorts, from where all safaris embark. From there, I, along with several others, bundled up in canters and drove into the woods with Chamaraj, a naturalist with The Serai Kabini, and driver, Abhi. As the sun rose on the horizon, winding roads led us to the entrance of the Nagarhole Tiger Reserve. With tiger sightings reported from safaris on the previous day, we charged ahead, our excitement mounting at every turn. Over the next 3.5 hours on the chilly morning, the very able duo whizzed past the forest as we spotted peahens, a peacock plume dance, several spotted deer, owlets, a serpent eagle, and monkeys. The reserve is home to 149 tigers, said Chamaraj, as we continued driving, eyes peeled for the elusive big cats. Safaris in Karnataka officially resumed recently following a temporary Government ban late last year



due to human-animal conflicts. The first monsoon safari season after lifting the ban has been promising, with tourists flocking to the region to experience the lush monsoon and thriving wildlife. Our safari, however, was a series of ups and downs. As drivers and naturalists exchanged calls and WhatsApp voice notes to trace tigers and other predators, the coordinated mission had us racing through the jungle following pug marks and elephant dung. Two hours in, it was time for a short tea break, and off we went again. We drove, paused at certain intersections, and greeted fellow safari-goers with disappointed looks as their canters and buses crossed paths. Then, at one such junction, a sudden call from a fellow driver at the other end of the forest sent Abhi into a speeding U-turn. We sped off, flying off our seats, hopeful that the big cat was ready for



A monsoon chase in Nagarhole

I went looking for tigers and found much more: otters, crocodiles, and a lush monsoon forest. Because in the jungle, nothing ever goes quite to plan

us. “A tiger has been spotted! If you see it, no videos, please!” said Chamaraj, as the canter made its way to the spot. Alas, we were met with pugmarks by the side of a waterbody where a tiger was spotted moments ago. Despite no tiger gracing us with its presence, the safari was a thrilling experience, and I kept my hopes up for the afternoon boat safari that was to follow. Back at The Serai Kabini overlooking the swollen Kabini River, a lavish baale yele oota

(a traditional Karnataka meal served on the plantain leaf) by Sous Chef Mudhassir awaited me. After a refreshing neer moru, I made my way through the kosumbari salad, Maddur vada, masala vada, obbattu, bisi bele bath, vegetable palya, poori, sambar, and a range of accompaniments: a perfect reset to tune in to the upcoming boat safari. Led by naturalist Shekar and his able captain Krishna, we gently waded down the Kabini River, passing tribal



(Clockwise from left) Villas at the resort; Shekar (centre) with guests on a Nature walk; a wild jackal; a tiger at Nagarhole Tiger Reserve; a peacock; and an outdoor dining experience at The Serai Kabini. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



villages, to enter the Nagarhole National Park. The river, says Shekar, originates in Wayanad and divides the Nagarhole National Park to the North and the Bandipur Wildlife Sanctuary to the South. The 3.5-hour experience was much calmer than the land safari and had a charm of its own. We spotted kingfishers, spotted deer, langurs, ospreys, a family of otters, a pack of wild jackals, and a pair of crocodiles basking in the warm afternoon sun. “It is not common to spot otters and crocodiles during the monsoon; we are lucky!” announced Shekar. With neither of the 149 tigers willing to make their appearance, he sensed the disappointment, but continued regaling us with stories and videos from previous sightings. “A mother and two cubs were spotted a few days earlier, and one tiger was spotted swimming across the river last week,” he said. Shekar has been with The Serai as a naturalist since 2007, two years after the property launched. On our Nature walk through the property the next morning, he shared insights on the region's biodiversity and how locals and tribal communities

Serai, by the river

- The Serai Kabini launched in 2005. The property spans over 60 acres (12 acres built-in).
- The property offers 20 exclusive riverside residences with views of the Kabini River.
- The Wildgrass restaurant helmed by Sous Chef Mudhassir offers a range of curated dining experiences such as an elaborate baale yele oota and a candlelit barbeque by the poolside.
- Safaris aside, guests can partake in Nature walks, kayaking, coracle rides, and a range of other outdoor activities such as archery and kite flying.
- To wind down, head to the Oma spa that has on offer a range of therapies and body treatments.

hour-long walk, we spotted several trees: red silk cotton, jamun, mahogany, gulmohar, and wild neem. With peacock calls for company, we spotted white-cheeked barnets, green bee eaters, a spotted dove, weaver birds busy stitching their nests, common swallows, and kingfishers. Byre Gowda, a local boatman – who takes guests on coracle rides and the sunset boat ride – has been with the resort since its inception. “Even when the jungle safaris were temporarily closed, we conducted Nature walks, bird safaris, and took guests on boats to experience the region's biodiversity,” he said, during a coracle boat ride. With birdsong and the riverfront for company, my visit to Kabini is complete. I may not have spotted a tiger, but the solitude, warm hospitality, and thrilling jungle rides were worth every minute. As front office manager Abdul Saleem advises every guest, “Go into the jungle with zero expectations, and come back with many memories.” I certainly did.

The writer was in Kabini on invitation from The Serai Kabini

continue to thrive off Nature's bounty. “Tribals rely on the forest for natural remedies: herbs and fruits,” he said, pointing to the jatropa plant whose milk is used to treat fevers and joint pains. On the

Brewing history

Hyderabad's coffee house ode to Taramati Baradari



Roastery Coffee House, inspired by the Qutb Shahi era. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Prabalika M Borah
prabalika.mg@thehindu.co.in

Taramati Baradari is a historic open-air pavilion built during the Qutb Shahi era, known for its striking architecture. Roastery Coffee House's latest outlet in Film Nagar – its third in Hyderabad and 15th nationally – is a contemporary interpretation of the 17th Century dance pavillion. Founder Nishant Sinha says the café borrows the original structure's strong geometry, repeated arches, symmetry, and rhythm. Unlike the monochromatic original, however, the café gets a playful update with pink, yellow, mint green, and blue across its walls. “We added colour because we wanted the space to feel happy and translate that feeling

into the café environment.” The food menu sticks to familiar café fare, without unnecessary desi twists on Asian dishes. Sandwiches, pasta and finger foods are among the popular picks. The club sandwich remains my personal favourite, though the hold-in sandwich, with chicken and avocado, is giving it some competition. What does one drink here? There is no shortage of coffee. The cappuccino is a bestseller among the hot beverages, while my pick is the Monsoon Malabar hot pour-over. The café's Gungegiri Estate beans recently won a Gold Award at the Global Coffee Awards (Asia), held in Charleston, US. What's next, I ask Nishant? “Bengaluru, with another exciting design to talk about.”

Prajwal Parajuly

Gangtok, my hometown in the Himalayan foothills, was a walker's city when we were growing up. We went everywhere on foot. Uphill from home to school. Downhill from school to home. Downhill from home to Paljor Stadium. Knee-obliterating uphill from Paljor Stadium to town. Uphill for Mr CSP Singh's Physics tuition classes at the crack of dawn. Up-down, up-down. Covering four to five kilometers a day on foot was normal. That was life in a tiny town perched on a hilltop. Between then and now, if anything, Gangtok has become an even better city for walkers. In 2009, we pedestrianised our main square, the MG Marg, one of the few stretches of straight road in town. It was here that everyone convened to shop, eat out and stroll. Prashant Pradhan – one of the architects instrumental in sowing the seeds of an automobile-free square and also responsible for designing some of the footpaths around town – tells me there were murmurs of discontent when the proposal to make MG Marg car-free was floated. Shop owners complained that the lack of vehicular traffic would destroy business. I remember residents wondering how they would ferry their sick grandmas to and from the hospital. The MG Marg soon became our pride and joy. It came “alive with people walking, meeting, and engaging with the city rather than simply driving through it,” Prashant says. Everyone – without exception – is thrilled with the change now. We may have had very little character, but we did succeed in making every other hill station look like our impoverished cousin. Middle-class domestic



ILLUSTRATION: SAAI

Walk in my shoes

Prajwal Parajuly reflects on what India's increasingly car-choked cities could learn from Gangtok's quiet, uphill rhythms

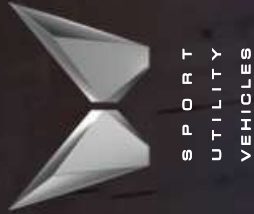
travellers, our tourism industry's bread and butter, marvelled at the cobbled path, the cleanliness and the foreignness of a vehicle-free city centre. Influencers yammered about the civic sense – no spitting! No litter! – in breathless tones. No overcrowding in vehicles, no public defecation, they roared. And yet no one spoke about the inherent walkability of the 150,000-strong city. As a somewhat well-travelled person, I am yet to find an Indian city that could brag about being as pedestrian-friendly as Sikkim's capital. A 12-kilometre footpath runs along the highway (yes, the highway). It snakes downhill into the suburbs of Tadong and

5th Mile and 6th Mile and does not stop until the next town over. You could walk all the way down to the neighbouring town of Ranipool without straying from the footpath. Our footpaths are actual footpaths. They have proper railings on both sides. There are some metros, like, Bengaluru and Delhi, that may not exactly be suitable for navigation on foot but have enough parks and outdoor spaces. Chennai, I sadly have to add, isn't one of those metros. Gangtok is that rare Indian city whose network of stairs, flyovers, and footpaths lends itself to a walking experience beyond just parks and gardens. You can completely run

errands on foot. One would think that a city that is as well-equipped to handle foot transportation as ours would have no traffic jams, but one would be wrong. Measures to keep car ownership under check – one isn't allowed to purchase an automobile unless one shows proof of parking space at home – can only help so much. The Government's odd-even rule has seen some traffic relaxation. But we people are mostly to blame. We are becoming too posh to walk these days. Places that were easily reachable by walking 20 years ago are now deemed inaccessible unless we get there by car. Wealthy people not wanting to be seen on foot unless

it is for a morning walk is a uniquely South Asian insecurity. In Gangtok, I have done it all. I have hiked all the way up monasteries and hilltop temples. I walk the short distance from home to Rachna Books – up the stairs, up the footpath, up the flyover, and up the footpath again before making my way downhill – because it takes half the time it would in a car. I walk to the dentist. I walk to the tailor. I walk to friends' houses. A cousin and I once attempted to cover in a day the 76 kilometres from Gangtok to Kalimpong, another hill station across the border in West Bengal, but had to abort it around the 60-kilometre mark, when it got too dark (There's something so cute and wonderfully provincial about a 60-kilometre walk along the highway). The residents take this great gift for granted. It is only when we encounter the no-walk zones that most South Asian cities are that we get smug about our good fortune. I can think of no other Indian city, big or small, with the exception of Chandigarh that is considerate of the walker. Shimla and Pondicherry try. So do Pune and Shillong, though less so. Aizwal, I have been told, is walkable. I will never take lightly my city's pedestrian-centricity because I live in Chennai part of the year. Frantic for a pleasant urban walking experience, I concoct ridiculous routes mixing and matching alleyways, where the cars whizz by too close for comfort; beaches, where the sun ruthlessly beats down; and traffic-clogged main roads, where footpaths are almost always non-existent. More often than not, I fail.

Prajwal Parajuly is a novelist. Karma and Lola, his new book, is forthcoming in mid-2027. He teaches Creative Writing at Krea University and oscillates between New York City and Sri City.



mahindra *Rise*

MIGHTY JUST GOT MIGHTIER

Now with Bigger Panoramic Skyroof™



Panoramic Skyroof™



Bigger HD Infotainment & Digital Cluster



540° Surround View



RANGE STARTS AT
₹ 13.69 LAKH*

SCORPIO N

THE BIG DADDY OF SUVs

**KHIVRAJKAMAL
MOTORS PVT. LTD.**

**Avadi, Ambattur,
Sriperumbudur, Chengalpattu:**
74281 90254

MM MOTORS:
Iyyappanthangal, Mount Road,

**Selaipur, Kavangarai,
Purasaiwakkam, Redhills:**
98849 99993

**AUTOMOTIVE
MANUFACTURERS PVT. LTD.**

**NM Road, OMR Thoraipakkam,
ECR, Chromepet,
Guduvanchery,
Tiruvallur: 74280 81659**

**JUBILANT
MOTORWORKS PVT. LTD.**

**Velachery, Nandanam,
Navalur:**
96675 04477

**JAIN CARS &
AUTO SALES (P) LTD.**

Arani, Kanchipuram:
84487 91677

*Creative Visualisation. For illustrative purpose only. Ex-Showroom price of 2Z variant (All-India). All features/specifications are not available in all variants and may vary. Please visit auto.mahindra.com or contact your nearest authorised Mahindra dealership for exact information.

Olan is now being turned into a consommé, pradhaman into cake, and pal payasam into ice cream. While some chefs are embracing the change, others say the sadya is not something that needs fixing

The sadya remix

Nivedita Jayaram Pawar

A red rice congee spiked with sambar spices and topped with avial vegetables. An olan, traditionally an ash gourd curry, reimagined as a consommé with grilled pineapple. A pradhaman recast as a toasted coconut cake drizzled with salted jaggery caramel. This was Chef Arthi Rathore's sadya at Indica, a pop up venue in Ghitorni near Gurugram, last year.

While on paper it barely resembles the meal it claims to have descended from, taste it though, and the flavours are unmistakably familiar just rearranged into a shape the feast has never taken before. For generations, the Onasadya has followed the same rules. Twenty-five dishes, give or take, arranged in a fixed order on a banana leaf, cooked more or less the same way for years. It is one of the few Indian feasts where the sequence matters as much as the food itself. That fixity is starting to crack with a handful of chefs now treating the sadya less as a

ritual to preserve and more as a format to work with.

"There's been a lot of innovation globally around food from the North of India, and almost none from the South. I wanted to show that southern food can be reimagined too, because of the sheer power of flavour we have here," says Arthi, a MasterChef India Tamil participant.

Chef Regi Mathew, who runs Kappa Chakka Kandhari in Chennai and Bengaluru, and Chatti in New York, has been serving sadya in restaurants since 2007. This year Chatti is running its own Onasadya as well with 27 dishes and the same uncompromising format.

Regi brings Namboodaris from Kerala to prepare the feast, keeping the customs around the meal as important as the food itself. He says, "A sadya has cultural nuances and rules. The Namboodaris start with prayers before the flame is even lit. I could cook it myself, but when they make it, it becomes more than a meal. It's our culture on a plate."

He points out that the number of dishes is always odd, 25 or 27, each



with a fixed place on the leaf that dictates the order in which it is eaten, building toward four payasams and ending in buttermilk for digestion. "It's all very logical, very scientific. When you put hot rice on a banana leaf, the polyphenols in it rupture and add flavour to the food. You can't get that with a plate. And you can't really enjoy a sadya with a spoon and fork, it has to be eaten with your hand," he insists.

More on the plate
The most radical version comes from co-founder and Executive Chef Sara Jacob Nair of Nair On Fire a chain of delivery kitchens in Mumbai, specialising in home-style Kerala cuisine. Her Onasadya keeps the traditional vegetarian spread intact and adds one non-vegetarian curry alongside a celebratory roast of

either prawn, fish, chicken, mutton or buff, a nod to how Syrian Christian households in Kerala have always folded meat and seafood into their celebrations. It is proved more popular than the original with over 60% of her customers now choosing the non-vegetarian version.

Her superfood sadya is built around black rice, palm jaggery, jackfruit and moringa, ingredients Sara sees not as trendy additions but as things Kerala cooking always relied on.

Her sadya on a thali turns the usual 20-30 dishes on a leaf into a course wise experience. "A Malayali doesn't need instructions, you just mix everything on the leaf and eat. But for someone unfamiliar with the



(Clockwise from far left) Nair on Fire Onasadya; Chefs Arthi Rathore and Akash Muralidharan at the onasadya pop up at Indica, Gurugram; and Onam special desserts at Punjab Grill, Dubai. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

cuisine 25-30 dishes can be overwhelming. This gives them an entry point," says Sara. She is firm this is not dilution.

At OMO in Gurugram, culinary director Chetna Chopra keeps the classic dishes intact, changing only a handful of ingredients such as a toran made with fiddlehead fern instead of beans, a pineapple puliserry and a payasam built around Kashmiri plums from a partner farm.

Sarada Krishnan, founder of South Side Mumbai a catering company in Mumbai and now also a supper club in Dubai, has cooked a traditional Onasadya every year for the past six years. This year she is giving a modern spin to the dishes and presenting each dish as a tasting portion. The menu includes parippu vada with puli inji and chammandi, moru curry balls and a pothichoru of Kerala red rice with sambar, avial, kalan, olan, thoran and manga curry, wrapped in banana leaf. "The intention is to honour the essence of the sadya while presenting it in a way that allows every guest to appreciate each individual preparation," she says.

At Punjab Grill in Dubai, brand Executive Chef Sandeep Ail has found a middle ground. He keeps all

the savoury dishes to their traditional forms and uses dessert for experimentation. His pal payasam becomes ice cream, served with ada pradhaman in a coconut shell, while jackfruit and tender coconut come together in a panna cotta. "The heart of a sadya lies in its iconic dishes like avial, olan, kalan and erissery, so we stayed true to those recipes," says Sandeep.

Marina Balakrishnan, founder of Mumbai's vegetarian Keralite food joint Oottupura, who hails from Kerala's Thalassery, is known for her traditional sadya. She says, "A sadya is already elevated. How do you elevate an avial by turning its sauce into a foam? The beauty of an avial is its rusticity, its earthiness, the way the vegetables are cut, the coarseness of coconut. There's a reason it's done that way."

She recalls a nine-course sadya she once encountered where the rasam was served through a percolator. "If something is already perfect in colour, flavour and texture, why meddle with it? If you serve it French style, is that still a sadya? The invention here was already made decades ago. You're only tampering with what was there before," she says.

The question is no longer whether the sadya can change. It is how much it can change before it becomes something else. Thankfully, the traditional sadya isn't going anywhere. Neither are the chefs trying to reinterpret it. This Onam, both are sharing the table.

Google's Pixel 11 series arrives in India from ₹89,999 with camera controls that shape a photo as it is taken, creator tools built into the camera app, and a returning notification light on the Pro models



The Google portfolio. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Fabian Rodrigues

Scroll back through your camera roll from the last three years, and a pattern emerges: faces evenly lit, skies intact, shadows gently raised and highlights pulled down. Every photograph has arrived, by slightly different routes, at the same image, competent, clean and looking rather more assembled than taken.

The Pixel 11, launched in India this week alongside the Pixel 11 Pro, Pixel 11 Pro XL and Pixel 11 Pro Fold, offers a way out. Its most interesting camera feature, Camera Looks, works by giving up control rather than accumulating more of it.

Apple and Samsung sell at enormous scale, so their cameras are built to get every picture right: the family shot against a bright window, the receipt, the child at a recital. That produces a very specific kind of 'polished image'. Google, with the Pixel a smaller, more niche business, has spent that freedom letting you make a mistake on purpose.

Camera Looks intervenes at the point of capture, with four base looks including Natural, Shadows

The Pixel pivot

and Vanilla, alongside creative presets such as Editorial, Velvet, Classic, Digi and Black Tie, roughly 10 in all and each adjustable. Google says they change how the phone stacks frames for HDR and how it handles sharpening, rather than applying a filter afterward. Digi captures fewer frames, letting highlights blow out and shadows fall away much like a cheap digital camera from 2005.

There is a trade-off: the Pixel decides when you press the shutter, while Apple's editing remains non-destructive. For anyone who has shot film, that is less a limitation than the appeal.

Magic Capture addresses the moment that happens half a

second after you decide to take a picture. The phone records a short burst of video, analyses around 400 frames in real time using on-device processing and Gemini models, then pulls out 12-megapixel stills, cropping and de-blurring them.

The phone finally takes creators seriously
Creator Suite, available on the Pro models, may be the most useful addition of all. It offers social-media grid lines, an audio visualiser, automatic clip organisation and, most usefully, a teleprompter that scrolls a script at the pace you are speaking as you record on the selfie camera.

For the small-business owner filming a product video, or the freelance social-media manager shooting eight client reels in an afternoon and re-recording each

one because the third line keeps escaping, that removes the need for a second phone, a paid teleprompter app or brute memorisation. The automatic folders matter too. The first obstacle to becoming a creator is rarely talent or equipment, and far more often, a camera roll of thousands of takes that nobody wants to sort through.

Small AI, working
Google's other additions are similarly modest and useful. Rambler is a Gemini-powered voice-input tool that strips out ums

and false starts, returning clean text. HiLight brings back something phones once did well: a ring around the camera flash glows when a favorite contact calls or when you are speaking to Gemini hands-free.

There was a decade when the most useful thing on a phone was a single blinking dot. The BlackBerry face down on a desk, red light pulsing, told you the world wanted something before you had touched it. The early Android years turned the notification LED into a small personal craft, green for one contact, purple for the one message you would leave a dinner table for. Somewhere between edge-to-edge screens and always-on displays, we let it go.

HiLight brings that instinct back, replacing the temperature sensor that sat on last year's Pro. It does exactly two things at launch, which is thin for a piece of hardware. It also changes something socially

interesting: turning your phone face down is a gesture with meaning, an announcement that you are present and the device is not. A light on the back edits that announcement, and whether it reads as considerate or intrusive depends on who is sitting across the table.

All four phones run the Tensor G6 with Titan M3 security and Gemini Nano on-device. The Pro and Pro XL add a 50MP main camera, a redesigned 48MP telephoto with 120x Pro Zoom and a 3,600-nit display; the Pixel 11 gets a 48MP sensor with 30x Super Res Zoom and Instant Night Sight. Storage starts at 256GB.

The Pixel Watch 5, launched alongside, adds blood pressure and insulin resistance trend summaries drawn from at least seven days of passive data, framed as early warnings rather than diagnoses.

The Pixel 11 Pro Fold is nearly 1mm thinner, about 10% lighter and three times more durable than its predecessor, with a composite back Google says is designed to be impossible to crack. The crease, though, is more visible than on some rivals. At ₹1,86,999 for 512GB, that is a trade-off buyers will have to make.

Prices start at ₹89,999 for the Pixel 11, ₹1,19,999 for the Pro and ₹1,34,999 for the Pro XL, with the Watch 5 at ₹42,900. Pre-orders opened on August 12, and retail begins August 20, alongside cashback, EMI and upgrade offers.

The Pro models now cost upwards of a lakh, which raises the fair question of how long they ought to last. Google's answer is seven years of OS and security updates, along with Pixel Drops.

Which brings us to the comparison nobody at Google will make out loud. Apple demonstrated a contextual, screen-aware Siri in June 2024, marketed a phone around it, and then took roughly 18 months to deliver the personalised features. Google spent that time shipping a teleprompter, a voice recorder that removes your filler words, a camera that lets you pick your own colour science, and a watch that tells you to get your bloodwork done. None of it dazzles, and all of it works on a Wednesday morning.

The Keralam code

Across brands, Onam fashion this year heralds nostalgia and Kerala-inspired imagery

Anasuya Menon and Shilpa Nair Anand
anasuya.m@thehindu.co.in | shilpa.nair@thehindu.co.in

A classic Malayalam film song, a fleeting Onam memory, the flowers that suddenly fill up our courtyards, the comforting feeling of being at home ... designers are spotlighting fresh perspectives and imagery related to Onam in their new collections.



Ivory Edit – Yarn Culture
Yarn Culture's Onam collection, every year, is called the Ivory Edit. This year, however, says Sayujya Sajilal, of the online store, that collection did not begin with a colour, a fabric or a trend. "It began with a memory. The idea was simple: the feeling of home during Onam. Rain collecting in the courtyard, the familiar sound of an old swing, flowers picked in the morning and left in a brass vessel before the house wakes up. These are small moments many

Malayalis have grown up with, and they became the starting point for the collection," she says.
The custom-designed saris, inspired by memories – Manjadi, Chethi, Mandaram, Thamara and Thamara Kattam – are florals. The designer picked elements from the pookalam and built a story around each one. First hand-sketches, it was hand-embroidered later.
Manjadi has tiny, red manjadi seeds embroidered across a sandal-toned Kerala cotton saree, with the motifs running along one side of the drape to keep the design understated while letting the embroidery stand out.
Then there is lotus-inspired Thamara Kattam, which is minimal. Small hot pink lotus motifs have been embroidered on a checkered cotton sari; a concept that has been carried into a half-and-half sari, one of the most requested styles this year, where the second half is finished in a vibrant pink. There are also soft cotton Ganga Jamuna saris with bold colour combinations including Kanakambaram orange and brown, black and maroon, teal and red, and maroon and green.
Shop this edit at [yarnculture.in](#)



Orma – House of Urmi
The House of Urmi derives its Onam collection from memory or Orma, a tribute to the cherished memories of old-world Onam. "This year's Onam collection is our interpretation of the simple, nostalgic Onam that many of us grew up hearing about or experienced. I wanted to celebrate the quieter moments, the joy of making pookkalam together, children on swings, women dancing, blooming Krishna kireedam flowers, parrots, and the lush landscapes that make Kerala so special," says the founder, Anjali.
The Kerala-inspired prints begin as original painted artworks, created by Anjali. These are then digitally printed onto fabric and finished with embroidery, which adds depth and texture.
"Through these motifs, the idea was to tell little stories of old-world Onam and preserve that warmth and innocence in a contemporary, wearable form. The idea was to create versatile festive wear that can be enjoyed during Onam and beyond. The saris are crafted in premium cotton, as it offers the ideal base to bring out the intricacy of the original hand-painted artworks with exceptional clarity and colour," Anjali adds.
Shop this collection at [houseofurmi.in](#)



The Hands Behind Onam Pranaah
Pranaah's Onam 2026 is a burst of colours. Founder of the label and designer Poornima Indrajith says she wanted something that reflected the spirit of the season. "It had to be different, yet it had to capture the essence of Onam," she says.
"The hands behind Onam... The festival is all about flowers and we decided to trace the flowers that are used in pookkalam, which is the main part of the festivities – where they come from, where the markets are, the people who work in these markets.... The collection is an appreciation for the hands behind the celebration," she says.
She uses prints on organza too, in a range titled Poovasantham. "Organza is such a breezy, flowy fabric and with all of these floral motifs, they can also be styled and worn to a cocktail party," says Poornima.
Available at the Pranaah store in Panampilly Nagar and [pranaah.com](#)

SATHYAM | ESCAPE | INOX CITY CENTRE | DEVI CINEPLEX | PVR AMPA | SANGAM | CASINO | EGA | KAMALA | PALAZZO | WOODLANDS | PVR VR MALL
PVR LUXE VELACHERY | PVR GRAND VELACHERY | PVR PALLAVARAM | CINEPOLIS OMR | INOX MARINA MALL | PVR ECR | PVR AEROHUB | PVR REDHILLS | INOX
NATIONAL | AGS TNAGAR | AGS MADURAVOYAL | AGS VILLIVAKKAM | AGS OMR | IDREAMS | BHARATH | KRISHNAVENI | PR MALL WALL TAX ROAD | S2 PERAMBUR
S2 THEYAGARAYA | GK PORUR | KASI ASHOK NAGAR | MAYAJAAL ECR | ROHINI KOYAMBEDU | VETRI CHROMPET | RAKKI & MURUGAN AMBATTUR | GREEN &
SVASAKTHI & LAKSHMIBALA PADI | GANGA KOLATHUR | SHANMUGA MOOLAKKADAI | VARADARAJA CHITLAPAKKAM | MEENAKSHI AVADI | RADHA REDHILLS
ODIYAN MANI THIRUVOTTIYUR | VIJAY INJAMBAKKAM | MANI & KK MINJUR | NATIONAL & VIDHYA TAMBARAM | GOPALAKRISHNA PORUR | JOTHI ST THOMAS
MYR GUDUVANCHERY | MK SRI PERUMBUDUR | RAKKI THIRUVALLUR & KELAMBAKKAM | MMM THIRUVALLUR | SRK & LATHA CHENGALPATTU | MIRAJ PERUMBAKKAM
VELAN NANGANALLUR | NADAMUNI VILLIVAKKAM | VELS CHEMBARAMBAKKAM | SEVEN SCREEN KILAMBAKKAM | VIGNESHWARA & SUNDAR POONAMALLEE
SAKTHI MADHARPAKKAM | REMY AVADI | SRI DURGA TIRUTANI | BABU & ARUNA KANCHEEPURAM | VELA THIRUNINRAVUR | GANESH & VELCO ANAKAPUTHUR



SATHYAM | ESCAPE | DEVI | INOX | ALBERT | WOODLANDS | SANGAM | EGA | PVR AMINIKKARAI | PALAZZO | KAMALA | S2 PERAMBUR | AGS TNAGAR | AGS VILLIVAKKAM | AGS OMR | AGS MADURAVOYAL
INOX VILUAMBAKKAM | INOX OMR | INOX VELACHERY | S2 THEYAGARAYA | PVR ANNANAGAR | PVR PALLAVARAM | PVR VELACHERY | PVR ECR | PVR REDHILLS | PVR MEENAMBAKKAM | CINEPOLIS OMR | MAYAJAAL
MIRAJ PERUMBAKKAM | KASI TALKIES | EVP CARNIVAL | VIJAY PARK ECR | ROHINI KOYAMBEDU | RAKKI AMBATTUR | MURUGAN AMBATTUR | RAKKI THIRUVALLUR | VARADARAJA CHITLAPAKKAM
GREEN CINEMAS PADI | VETRI CHROMPET | GANGA KOLATHUR | C3 MAMANDUR | SVASAKTHI PADI | GANESH ANAKAPUTHUR | LAKSHMI BALA PADI | VETRIVEL NANGANALLUR | SAK CHENGALPET
VELA THIRUNINRAVUR | GK CINEMAS PORUR | GK KARUMARI VILUAMBAKKAM | MANI MINJUR | RADHA REDHILLS | SUNDHAR POONAMALLEE | DURGA THIRUTANI | BABU KANCHIPURAM | ARUNA KANCHIPURAM
LATHA CHENGALPET | PARIMALAM KUNDARTHUR | MR TAMBARAM | KUMARI UTHUKOTTAI | GOLDEN THIRUTANI | AVK CINEMAS MARPEDU



Malayalam

Vismaya Mohanlal's revenge thriller



SR Praveen
praveen.sr@thehindu.co.in

Rarely have we seen an actor's name attached to the film's name. The CBFC certificate for *Thudakkam*, directed by Judy Anthany Joseph, displays the film's name as 'Vismaya Mohanlal's Thudakkam', heralding the debut film of actor Mohanlal's daughter. Mohanlal appears in a cameo role as a martial arts master and tells Meenu (Vismaya) that this is her "Thudakkam" (beginning) and to "make your father proud". Though Sai Kumar plays her father in the film, what is implied is not lost on anyone.

Part of this approach is the brand of writing that has marked Jude's films till now. Although he has a knack for keeping the narrative engaging, he also has a habit of overstating the obvious with needless expository scenes and cliched dialogues. This habit, combined with the inherent needs of a launch vehicle like *Thudakkam*, means that one would be served with several such scenes stating the obvious, which is also meant to excite the star's fan base.

Right from the prologue, which provides a glimpse into the levels of cruelty and criminality of the antagonist (Ashish Joe Antony), followed by a montage of the idyllic life led by Meenu and her father, the movie lays everything out in the open. Not much is done in the screenplay co-written by Jude with Akhil Krishna and Linish Nellikkal to upset expectations or spring surprises.

Perhaps the one element that stands out is Vismaya's mastery of the martial art Muay Thai, which plays an integral part in the story, much like how her brother Pranav Mohanlal's parkour skills were utilised in his debut *Aadhi* (2018). Some of these impactful fight sequences lift the film, which stays true to its generic ambitions, without any attempts at novelty. Her fighting flexibility is at times reminiscent of her father's action sequences.

Much of the screenplay banks on the overused trope of sexual violence and revenge. Yet, the tension surrounding one of the central events keeps the movie in watchable territory. A police officer's comment that sets tongues wagging in the neighbourhood appeared silly. Some of the writing choices are perplexing, like how Ashish, the antagonist, gets to utter just one line in the entire movie, remaining mute even in scenes where another character speaks to him. Though he manages to radiate menace, the monotonous expression gets tiring after a point. The star cameo doesn't add anything to the movie.

If not for the thoughtful weaving in of Vismaya's martial arts skills, *Thudakkam* would have ended up as just another generic revenge thriller. She manages to kick it up into average territory.

Thudakkam is currently running in theatres

Madhavan powers an important story

Tamil

Srinivasa Ramanujam
srinivasa.r@thehindu.co.in

Men and machines. It's a love story that defies logic. The soulful 2024 Tamil film *Meiyazhagan* explored the relationship between the protagonist and his cycle, and what the vehicle really meant to him. "In a way, this cycle coming into our lives changed it completely," a teary-eyed Karthi tells Arvind Swamy in the film.

G.D.N kickstarts proceedings with this fascinating emotion. A young Gopalaswamy Doraiswamy Naidu (GDN) follows an Englishman around for two years – not because he wanted to be friends, but because he was besotted with the motorcycle that he was riding. A few minutes into the film, a star-stuck Dorai asks the Englishman (who he ironically also calls 'Dorai' which means 'master') if he can sell him the motorcycle.

It would be the start of a lifelong



tryst with vehicles and machines.

But it's not just that alone that Naidu is fascinated by; "*Padippu solli kudu kadha neraya vishayam en aarvam solli kudukkum* (what my education doesn't teach me my enthusiasm will)," Naidu tells someone in a sequence.

Based on inventor and industrial pioneer GD Naidu, Madhavan's latest biopic on the big screen captures the highs and lows of the life of an ambitious man who dreamed big. *G.D.N* is indeed an important piece of work – for, it seeks to educate audiences about a personality who

might have changed the fortunes of thousands, if not for insecurity among other fellow Indians.

Don't let the word 'educate' fool you. Unlike some other biopics, *G.D.N* - directed by Krishnakumar Ramkumar - packs a bit of commercial punch as well, through the arrival of an Income Tax officer named Krishnan (Jayaraman) who is hell bent on proving that Naidu is a tax dodger. The interval block, in fact, does not even feature the protagonist himself; but two seasoned actors, Jayaraman and Sathyaraj (who plays Pillai, Naidu's friend and colleague), facing off in an electric sequence. It's the kind of commercial hero-villain face-off that you would least expect in a biopic of an inventor - which is what makes *G.D.N* reasonably entertaining.

Yet, for all its ambition, it struggles to invest in its quieter moments. The emotional heft in the story is often undercooked - Naidu's decision to choose a second wife (Ranganayaki, played by Dushara Vijayan) over his first love, Chellamma, is barely substantiated. Major events such as the Second

World War are hurriedly interspersed with the protagonist's interactions with NS Krishnan, MR Radha and Periyar... these events span long periods of time but are constructed within seconds in the film, thus making transitions abrupt.

Madhavan has found a niche playing real-life personalities. Be it his role in *Dhurandhar* or as Nambi Narayanan in *Rocketry: The Nambi Effect* or his latest role in *G.D.N*, the actor seems to thrive playing characters who have actually lived rather than imagined. And within

the limitations that such personalities possess, Madhavan sinks his teeth in. There's a stretch where he has received some painful news over a phone call from Germany; his reactions show Madhavan's growth as an actor. Of course, there's also Govind Vasantha's score that elevates the impact in these scenes.

The curiosity of Naidu and how he handles setbacks forms the core of *G.D.N*. While the former has been adequately addressed, the latter could have been written with more depth. This is where one feels that director Krishnakumar and team could have upped the game; rather than trying to pack in so much of the man's life inside the 147-minute timeline, they could have selected a few highlight moments to showcase. This would have allowed the film to breathe a little more. But for bringing to fore an overlooked visionary who deserved wider recognition, *G.D.N* will be an important film.

G.D.N is currently running in theatres

at the movies



Anirudh Ravichander goes berserk

A crafty paean to cinematic violence, *DC* is slick with some superbly staged action set pieces, but its emotional undercurrents rarely live up to Anirudh's spectacular score

Tamil

Bhuvanesh Chandar
bhuvanesh.chandar@thehindu.co.in

After finding a method to madness in his impressive debut, *Rocky*, filmmaker Arun Matheswaran has been struggling to find fresher ways to explore human depravity and celebrate cinematic violence. After *Rocky*, every successive film has felt less grounded and more emotionally contrived, as if even the slightest scope for lyricism in writing exists only to propel the oncoming action set piece. This is once again the case with his latest film, *DC*, whose title denotes the two central characters, Devadas (Lokesh Kanagaraj) and Chandra (Wamiqa Gabbi).

Arun's leading men have come across as emotionally stunted, and this is the case with Lokesh's Devadas as well. He has the same thirst for violence, but the emotional core feels eroded. Chandra, however, refrains from becoming *Saani Kaayidham's* Ponni. Chandra here, thankfully, is the soul of the story. Her feminine rage often promises to satisfyingly thwart the bloated egos of the men who populate her world, but Arun gives us enough to show us the girl child who has been imprisoned for life.

On one hand, Das is a gangster who is aware of how big his world is, but is fed up with the disparity and injustice in human society. Chandra, meanwhile, is a sex worker who was sold off at the age of six and has remained in her room for over 18 years. If Das is a beast who grew up in war and mayhem, Chandra is a caged spirit brutalised all day – Arun keeps asserting this primal difference to give us the satisfaction of when they eventually meet and change each other's lives.

But neither Das nor Chandra are saints; these are morally grey characters who don't hesitate to kill to survive. And in *DC*, their daggers and guns taste more blood than in any recent Tamil film. In fact, much of the story of *DC* feels spring-loaded for this mad, mad mayhem. On paper, the story all feels time-worn; but in effect, it works ... almost. After hitting a

DC

Director: Arun Matheswaran

Cast: Lokesh Kanagaraj, Wamiqa Gabbi, Sanjana Krishnamoorthy, Krish Dayal

Storyline: Devadas, a gangster haunted by loss, and Chandra, a sex worker brutalised by a lifetime of exploitation, find themselves drawn together as they wage a bloody war against the corrupt cops

consignment of the police department's ammunition in Gobichettipalayam and exacting revenge upon a cop, Das and other henchmen in his team – all working under cop-turned-gangster Arasu (Thalaivasal Vijay) – take refuge in a lodge in Chennai to escape from Inspector Bhojraj (Krish Dayal) and his team of cops. There, Das meets a bar singer, Parvathy (Sanjana Krishnamoorthy), but this illaiyaraaja-assisted meet-cute ends tragically. Simultaneously, we begin to see the story of a sex worker called Chandra.

This is essentially Arun attempting to put a twist on the classic 'Devadas' story by Sarat Chandra Chattopadhyay: what if Devadas loses Parvathy before they can even fall in love or ruminate on the possibility? And what if Devadas was a brash gangster with a mean streak? What if Parvathy wasn't in his fate, but another woman, who also comes from waging a long war herself? And what if this Devadas ends up playing a Robin Hood-like figure?

Interestingly, Arun's scheme works for much of the first half. The setting offers enough scope for strong character arcs, but what really captivates your attention are the superb action scenes. In fact, every set piece in *DC* is a lesson on action choreography. Even a shootout at a wedding hall thrills you endlessly. The standout action scenes in the film follow the mini-revenge arcs that Devadas and Chandra traverse during their cat-and-mouse with traitors, debaucherous men, and corrupt cops. After a point, though, the violence-heavy action feels repetitive and without proper emotional propulsion. Bullets shower as rain and cops die like flies, and every time Das and Co face trouble, you know they will escape, only to somehow cross paths with the cops again and open fire – it's as if it were all a game of police dress-up with a toy set.

The primary issue plaguing the film, as stated above, is the weak emotional core. At some point, Das asks Chandra what she knows about him, and she tells him everything she knows – about how he lost his mother, his feelings about his estranged father, about the deaths of Parvathy and his friend Sebastian, and that he is afraid of losing her. In truth, this is everything that defines Das' character.



Scan the QR Code for more entertainment news.

G.D.N

Director: Krishnakumar Ramkumar

Cast: R Madhavan, Sathyaraj, Jayaram, Priyamani, Dushara Vijayan, Vinay Rai,

Story: All about the life and times of inventor GD Naidu

The Last House

Director: Louis Leterrier

Cast: Wagner Moura, Greta Lee, Riley Chung, Emma Ho

Storyline: A family of four are suddenly sealed inside their home with no way out, and must work together to survive against both their dwindling resources and the mysterious, looming threat that is keeping them trapped.



Housebound by incuriosity

English

Ayaan Paul Chowdhury
ayaan.paul@thehindu.co.in

After years of choreographing action-packed mayhem, the director behind *The Transporter* films, *The Incredible Hulk*, *Now You See Me* and, most recently, *Fast X*, has made a perplexing career pivot. *The Last House*, his latest film for Netflix, shrinks that blockbuster canvas considerably. Set almost entirely inside a suburban Seattle home, the story follows Jason Delgado, an unemployed engineer played by Wagner Moura, his wife Ann, played by Greta Lee, and their two

children, after an unexplained phenomenon seals every door and window shut during a torrential rainstorm, trapping them indoors. Meanwhile, an unseen force gradually consumes the outside world. In theory, this sounds like an elegant inversion of the home-invasion thriller. The Netflix-bingeing audience has already experienced versions of this nightmare, since COVID permanently rewired how confinement is remembered. There are moments where the illusion of pandemic-era nostalgia works really well because Leterrier understands that the most convincing parts of survival are spectacularly boring and that survival is fundamentally repetitive. The Delgados ration food,

trade handwritten messages with neighbours marooned across the street, and cycle through vinyl and the same pair of DVDs because every digital connection has collapsed. Unfortunately, every promising thread evaporates before any semblance of genuine interrogation begins. The kids, Graham, and Ruth represent a generation whose emotional vocabulary has been shaped by feeds and recommendation algorithms, which makes the screenplay's indifference towards permanent disconnection genuinely baffling. Wagner Moura and Greta Lee spend two hours performing triage on dialogue that repeatedly flatlines beneath them. Every time Leterrier remembers these are gifted actors, the film briefly develops a pulse. Every time either of them opens their mouth to explain the plot, that pulse drops again. Once the initial mystery

of the lockdown wears off, *The Last House* discovers surprisingly little to do beyond watching four thinly sketched characters cycle through yet another survival problem. The opening hour crawls through with surprisingly little escalation, then the film abruptly dumps its creature-feature exposition, which feels determined to make up for lost time. For a story borrowing so heavily from one of the defining collective experiences of the twenty-first century, its curiosity about that experience remains remarkably limited. That leaves precious little worth sticking around for beyond Moura and Lee getting spectacularly baked, giggling through *Air Force One*, and those surprisingly solid anthropomorphised, Cthulhu-inspired creature designs.

The Last House is currently streaming on Netflix

Snippets



Farhan Akhtar, Ritesh Sidhwani launch Excel Origins

Actor-director-producer Farhan Akhtar and Ritesh Sidhwani have launched "Excel Origins", a new initiative dedicated to discovering, developing and backing the next generation of Indian filmmakers under 30 at their production house Excel Entertainment has completed 25 years since the release of their first film, *Dil Chahta Hai*. They shared the news with a post on their Instagram handle. "25 years ago, we started Excel Entertainment and began work on a film called *Dil Chahta Hai*. We had a simple thought - New voices and a different way of telling stories will find an audience. We were twenty-six years old. We didn't have all the answers, but we had the courage to take risks and the tenacity to make it happen," they said.



Game of Thrones: Aegon's Conquest gets theatrical release after 2027

The first *Game of Thrones* feature film has received a significant release update, with Warner Bros. confirming that *Game of Thrones: Aegon's Conquest* will be part of its theatrical slate beyond 2027. The announcement comes through Warner Bros. Discovery's second-quarter 2026 shareholders' letter, which places the film among the studio's post-2027 theatrical projects alongside new entries in *The Matrix*, *Batman* and *The Jetsons*. The studio has yet to announce a specific release date, meaning 2028 is currently the earliest possible window, with a 2029 release also looking plausible given the project's current stage of development.



NP 51: Nivin Pauly's next announced

Actor Rukmini Vasanth, who broke through with her memorable performance in the *Sapta Saagaradaache Eello* movies, is set for her debut in the Malayalam industry. The Bengaluru-based actor will star opposite Nivin Pauly in a film to be directed by debutant Nashid Famy. The project marks the 51st film of Nivin. The makers announced the project with a pooja ceremony on August 9. The movie is jointly produced by Martin Prakatt Films and Nivin's banner, Pauly Jr Pictures. Nivin's long-time collaborator, actor Aju Varghese, is set to play an important character in the movie. Nashid had written the blockbuster *Jaya Jaya Jaya Jaya Hey*, starring Darshana Rajendran and Basil Joseph.



Jason Sudeikis returns

Three years after the final whistle, *Ted Lasso* is back on the pitch, and while the old playbook still works, the Lady Greyhounds could use a few new plays

Streaming

Ayaan Paul Chowdhury
ayaan.paul@thehindu.co.in

There is something immediately comforting about seeing *Ted Lasso* again. Three years after the third season seemed to close the book, Jason Sudeikis's moustachioed optimist has slipped back into that beloved Midwestern geniality that made him one of the most endearing characters in modern TV comedy. The revival begins by confronting the question of why Ted would even return to Richmond after making such a definitive choice to go home. He has spent the intervening years in Kansas City, working at a supermarket while remaining closely involved with his son Henry. The club's imperiously maternal CEO and owner, Rebecca (Hannah Waddingham), the PR executive turned marketing boss Keeley (Juno Temple), and the softly spoken operations man Higgins (Jeremy Swift) eventually arrive with an offer to coach Richmond's new women's team, and after the requisite hesitation, Ted asks Henry and his mother Michelle to move to England with him. The directness of that decision exists because the series simply needs Ted back, but its logic is consequently thin. Once back in London, though, the Richmond machinery starts humming again. Ted applies his tried-and-tested therapeutic optimism to a second-division women's team facing financial limitations and cultural prejudice. The jokes are pleasant, and the football remains photographed with the clean, buoyant energy. Watching these familiar faces occupy the same spaces again has an undeniable warmth. The show knows how much affection its audience has accumulated for them, and it handles that affection with care. The women's team gives *Ted Lasso* its most promising new material because the problems facing the Lady Greyhounds possess a physical reality that Ted's old parabolic vocabulary cannot simply talk

Ted Lasso Season 4

Creator: Jason Sudeikis, Bill Lawrence, Brendan Hunt, Joe Kelly

Cast: Jason Sudeikis, Hannah Waddingham, Juno Temple, Brett Goldstein, Brendan Hunt, Jeremy Swift, Tanya Reynolds, Jude Mack, Faye Marsay, Rex Hayes, Aisling Sharkey, Abbie Hern, Grant Feely

Episodes: 5 of 10

Storyline: Ted returns to Richmond to coach the club's second-division women's football team, the Lady Greyhounds

away. The club has fewer resources, women's football receives less institutional attention, and players have to negotiate practical pressures. The premise creates an opportunity for the series to let its characters confront structures that cannot be fixed through a whiteboard exercise. The first five episodes only partly seize that opportunity. *Sex Education* breakout Tanya Reynolds is the strongest addition as Alice Chilton, a former player and assistant coach. Reynolds plays Alice with a wonderfully economical physicality, keeping her face rigid while Ted attempts to invade her emotional perimeter with the same persistence he once applied to Roy Kent and Nate. Her resentment also has a legitimate institutional basis: she was overlooked for the head coaching position, and Rebecca admits that she was never seriously considered. That exchange gives Alice something sharper than the usual *Ted Lasso* woundedness. She has a grievance with a material cause. The players have received thinner treatment so far. *Andor* and *Adolescence* star Faye Marsay's character is introduced largely through motherhood, while the rest of the squad register through reductive shorthand: sisters, a couple, a law student, and a slightly off-kilter goalkeeper, Boots (Jude Mack), who remains my favourite of the new players so far. The original Richmond ensemble took time to acquire individual textures through locker-room rivalries and accumulated interaction. But the new team has barely been given enough dramatic value to become a team before the returning cast starts reclaiming it. That overcrowding also exposes the revival's central problem. Roy and Keeley remain trapped in their frustrating romantic holding pattern, despite the mileage that the relationship has already extracted from the audience. Brendan Hunt's Coach Beard remains integrated in weird, almost grating ways despite the new women's team focus. Rebecca and Keeley continue to receive substantial space because their friendship remains one of the show's most reliable emotional mechanisms. These characters are played with the same confidence as ever, yet inertia has started to set in. There is an interesting adjustment in

tone. Season 4 is definitely less interested in the grand emotional speeches and pop-psychology excavations that eventually bloated Season 3 (even if we still get a fair share of those). Its problems are smaller, and its solutions are consequently easier to digest, which gives the awkwardness and tension of building a squad from scratch a lighter rhythm. And the show genuinely seems happiest and at its best when it stops trying to manufacture a major emotional revelation and lets its characters solve a problem together – the clique-breaking exercise that culminates in the bar quiz in Episode 4, "Greyhounds Day Off," is an excellent demonstration of that instinct. That may ultimately be the best version of this revival. *Ted Lasso* still understands how to make kindness feel pleasant when expressed through behaviour, especially in the small interactions between people who have known each other for years. Sudeikis, for one, remains perfectly calibrated to Ted's peculiar combination of folksy American metaphors and saccharine charm, all of which are just as effective as ever. The frustration comes from how little those rhythms have changed. In 2020, Ted's undying friendliness collided with a genuine sense of uncertainty. Four seasons later, the show has already demonstrated that optimism works, and the question has consequently shifted toward what it can accomplish when optimism encounters circumstances that require something else. Season 4 has the ingredients for that experiment in women's football, yet the first five episodes are still mostly content to preserve the old recipe. There is still pleasure in that preservation, of course. *Ted Lasso* remains breezy, polished and deeply committed to making us feel good. It is an easy show to spend time with, which definitely matters. It simply becomes harder to mistake that comfort for any sense of creative renewal. The Lady Greyhounds could give Ted Lasso a new problem worth solving, but so far, the series seems happiest solving the problem of getting Ted Lasso back.

Ted Lasso Season 4 is currently streaming on Apple TV, with new episodes releasing weekly on Wednesdays through October 7.